CHAPTER I

Buddhism

1 Introduction

Epistemology, the theory of knowledge, is a philosophical branch that examines the nature, origins, limitations, and validity of knowledge. The term "epistemology" derives from the Greek terms "episteme" and "logos". The term "logos" can be interpreted as "account," "argue," or "reason," whereas "episteme" may be comprehended as "knowledge", "understanding", or "acquaintance". Each of these varied translations encapsulates a distinct aspect of the meaning of the Greek phrase while simultaneously reflecting multiple dimensions of epistemology. Although the term "epistemology" is relatively recent, the discipline itself is as ancient as any other philosophical branch. Throughout the extensive history of epistemology, many periods have garnered significant attention in specific parts of the field. Plato's epistemology aimed to elucidate the essence of knowledge, distinguishing it from mere accurate opinion, while emphasising its significance for the individual who holds it. Kant's epistemology sought to examine the conditions that facilitate human understanding, while Russell's epistemology aimed to substantiate modern science through sensory experience. Locke's epistemology aims to elucidate the processes of human knowledge, whereas Kant's endeavours to investigate the prerequisites that facilitate human understanding. Recent endeavours in formal epistemology have focused on clarifying how our confidence levels are rationally influenced by our evidence. Conversely, modern feminist epistemology examines how our desires influence our evidence and, more broadly, our rational limitations.

Indian philosophy

Indian philosophy has a longer history of continuous development than any other philosophical tradition, featuring a wide variety of schools and systems. Virtually every Indian philosophical tradition is associated with a religious sect, including the six orthodox (astika) schools (darshanas) such as Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Samkhya, Yoga, Purva Mimamsa, and Vedanta, alongside the heterodox (nastika) schools, which consist of Buddhism, Jainism, and the materialistic Carvaka school. All Indian philosophical traditions demonstrate numerous shared ideas. In the Indian context, discussions within educational institutions primarily centre on epistemological issues; however, no author examines knowledge devoid of the metaphysical

commitments intrinsic to various classical systems (darśana), encompassing realist and idealist, dualist and monist, as well as theist and atheist viewpoints, among others. Each of the principal schools, totalling approximately twelve, delineates a position on knowledge and justification from the inception of its history, even if, as demonstrated by the Buddhist sceptic (Prasaṅgika), it predominantly challenges the theories of others. Nevertheless, certain common epistemological assumptions or attitudes are present, the most significant of which is a focus on the origin of belief or justification. Mainstream classical Indian epistemology is predominantly defined by notions of genealogy, particularly with knowledge-generating processes known as pramāṇas, which translates to "knowledge sources". The principal options are perception, inference, and testimony. Other processes seem to lack truth-conduciveness or cannot be distilled from one or more of the widely recognised sources, such as perception and inference.

Since antiquity, the essence of knowledge, referred to as 'jñāna', has been a central focus in philosophy. This subject has attracted the most attention from intellectuals globally. This concept holds significance throughout various systems of Indian philosophy. Every philosophy posits that ignorance is the principal cause of human suffering. Consequently, possessing precise knowledge is vital to eliminate pain from the world. What precisely constitutes knowledge? What are the sources of the information? What is the criterion for assessing the veracity of knowledge? In summary, these are several epistemological issues that drive the formulation of a theory of knowledge within the domain of epistemology. Epistemology, a branch of philosophy, examines the nature of human knowledge and the means of its justification. This branch of philosophy examines the origin, nature, techniques, validity, and limits of knowing.

The notion of knowledge can be regarded as a conviction about reality within the framework of philosophical examination. All practical endeavours are based on knowledge. The objective of knowledge is to illuminate what is inherently obscure. A known object and a conscious person are both essential elements of knowledge. Knowledge cannot exist without both a subject and an object of knowledge. The individual possesses this property. Several alternative terms for knowledge include buddhi, denoting understanding; upalabdhi, signifying apprehension; and pratyaya, representing concepts, judgement, awareness, and cognition. The definitions of these two terms are synonymous. In Indian epistemology, the notion of knowing is denoted by two terms: jñāna and pramā.

The name 'jñāna' is derived from the root 'jna', meaning 'to know'. All forms of knowledge, including correct, incorrect, valid, invalid, true, and false, belong to the domain of Jñāna.

'Pramā' is a term formed from the root 'ma' and the prefix 'pra', signifying valid knowledge. According to Nagesa, valid knowledge is entirely novel and aligns with its object (avisaṁvadijñāna). The term 'pramā' is solely utilised to denote authentic knowledge, referred to as 'yathārtha jñāna'. It is utilised to signify knowledge from a psychological standpoint that aids in comprehending an object's true nature. Knowledge was employed not only for metaphysics during the Upaniṣadic era but also for several other objectives. The term 'jñāna' in Advaita Vedanta denotes both absolute knowledge (svarūpa jñāna) and empirical knowledge (vṛtti jñāna). They contend that vṛtti jñāna qualifies as 'jñāna' when illuminated by the principle of consciousness, referred to as Brahman (or atman). Various schools of thought exist within Indian philosophy about the concept of knowing. This essay will analyse the perspectives and knowledge of only two schools: Nyāya and Buddhism.

Buddhism

Buddhist epistemology is the philosophical examination of knowledge and legitimate cognition within the Buddhist tradition. A main focus is the process of acquiring authentic knowledge and how this knowledge facilitates the eradication of ignorance (avijjā), the fundamental root of suffering. Buddhist epistemology, unlike most other Indian philosophical traditions, is distinctly factual, analytical, and focused on liberation. It prioritises actual experience and rational analysis over metaphysical conjecture.

Each philosophical tradition in India has endeavoured to formulate a theory of knowledge, referred to as the Pramana Sastra, that underpins the metaphysical structure of the respective school. Although the primary objective of philosophy is widely recognised as the acquisition of knowledge of reality (tattva-jhana), it is thought that a theory of knowledge is an essential prerequisite for a theory of reality. The premise that philosophising involves contemplating the essence of reality as revealed through experience underpins this belief. On the other hand, because every experience involves a cognitive reference to an object, there is always a persistent risk of misinterpreting this connection. Although every experience contains an inherent trans phenomenality or self-transcendence, it does not guarantee that it will reveal its object in an acceptable and truthful manner. An inquiry about the veracity of the experience is necessary due to the potential for error therein. This work serves as the foundation and center of the entire epistemological endeavour. Consequently, scholars within the Buddhist tradition strive to construct a robust epistemological basis for their understanding of reality.

Buddhist philosophy is a moral framework that emerged in India between the sixth and fifth centuries BCE. It is a non-theistic tradition of Indian philosophy. Initially, the sagacious Siddhartha Gautama founded it. During a time when India was undergoing a significant religious and intellectual transformation, the Buddha established a belief system that would subsequently be recognised as Christianity. Upon attaining this realisation, the Buddha discerned that the origins of suffering were desire and attachment and that humanity's suffering stemmed from ignorance of the true nature of existence.

Buddhist philosophy has focused on a no-substance ontology. The profound desire to eliminate suffering drove Gautama, the Buddha, who founded Buddhist philosophy, to contemplation. He conceptualised that all pain arises from 'tanha' (desire) and that all desire stems from connection to the illusory belief in permanence. He sought to propose a solution to the labyrinth of suffering, presenting impermanence or nonsubstantiality as the essential means to transcend suffering. The Four Noble Truths support the concepts of impermanence and nonsubstantiality as means to eliminate suffering.

The Buddha has interpreted the entirety of reality, typically perceived through the lenses of matter and consciousness, as a succession of transient moments. The term "moment" implies that all reality or existence is intrinsically linked to time. Everything that exists is confined within the limits of time. Consequently, an existence series is synonymous with a time series. The existence series may be physical, psychological, or a synthesis of both. Each series is, in essence, a conglomerate. A material entity is a physical agglomeration (bhuta sanghdta), while a mental entity is a psychical aggregation (citia sanghdta). In Buddhism, wisdom is characterised by understanding and discernment. It includes self-awareness of the body and mind, reflection on the inevitability of death, and the recognition that all complex entities are subject to change and, hence, are not worthy of pursuit. Wisdom entails acknowledging that humans lack total control over their bodies, thoughts, or personalities; hence, these elements do not define one's inner self and are not possessed by any single individual. Conversely, everything that exists is really an impersonal endeavour. Due to the complexities that govern every event, it is impossible for anyone to exert perfect control over all factors, which means that while we may strive for control, we must also accept the unpredictability of outcomes. Nonetheless, the potential to alter certain life circumstances, such as improving personal skills or achieving specific goals, renders discipline and practice worthwhile, irrespective of their inherent difficulties.

Buddhists were tasked with formulating a theory that elucidates the deceptive nature of standard knowledge acquisition methods and provides a framework for rectifying the faults arising from their use. A notable advancement in this area is the development of arguments contesting the idea that specific practices typically employed to establish beliefs generate knowledge.

An object is defined as something that exists inside the realm of awareness. It is exhibited either directly or indirectly in manifestation. The entity that is directly accessible to consciousness is termed the object of perception, while the entity that is not immediately accessible is termed the object of inference. Conversely, the object of perception is inherently situated within the dimensions of space and time, but the object of inference is initially conceptualised through a sign and then located in a more abstract realm, such as through reasoning or deduction based on available evidence. Consequently, there exist only two categories of objects: objects of perception and objects of inference.

The reliability of knowledge relies on two sources: sensory experience and inference. Only information sourced from these two sources can be accepted as true. The phrase "attainable item" refers to accurate knowledge obtained by sensory perception and inference. Consequently, knowledge acquired through means apart from perception and inference lacks validity. The presence of this information is perpetually an illusion. An essential feature of possessing accurate knowledge is the ability to identify factors that motivate individuals to undertake intentional actions in pursuit of fulfilling their needs. Consequently, knowledge that is both precise and functional is characterised as information that identifies an entity that meets our criteria.

According to several Buddhist schools, "right knowledge is knowledge that is not refuted by experience." Knowledge is accurate and valid when it can refer to a specific entity. Knowledge does not generate or furnish any item; it only directs our focus towards the object. Consequently, knowledge is deemed accurate when it motivates us to pursue attainable objectives and when it directs us toward the truth. False cognition is a type of cognitive process that leads us to perceive an object that differs from the one we possess. An object can assume various shapes, contingent upon diverse spatiotemporal contexts. Consequently, any sort of cognition that discloses merely a singular aspect or shape of an object cannot be regarded as genuine knowledge. Cognition cannot be deemed accurate if it reveals the erroneous position and time of an object.

Dharmakirti

Dharmakirti not only learned the doctrines of Vasubandhu and Dinnaga but also excelled in their application. Seven works by Dharmakirti are recognised and accessible. Among them, Pramana Vartika is the most distinguished. Pramana Vartika represents an enhancement of Dinnaga's perspective articulated in Pramana Samuccaya, and it exceeds the latter work. It comprises four chapters. The first deals with the examination of the pramanas in general, the second with pratyaksa as pramana, the third with inference (svarthanumana), and the fourth with syllogism (pardrthanumana). Dharmakirti's subsequent work is Pramana Viniscaya. It is a summary of Pramana Vartika. The third piece is Nyaya Bindu, which constitutes a further condensation. The remaining four volumes are concise treatises focused on particular subjects. Hetu Bindu is a concise categorisation of logical justifications. Sambandha Pariksd is an analysis of relational issues. Codana Prakarana is a discourse on the practice of engaging in debate. Santanantara Siddhih is a discourse on the nature of other minds. It seeks to disprove solipsism.

“All effective human endeavours are invariably preceded by knowledge.” 2 In this introductory statement, Dharmakirti delineates the scope and objectives of epistemology and logic in the Nyaya Bindu. Human behaviour can be either intentional or instinctive. The aim of humanity is once again either favourable or unfavourable. An intentional action informed by knowledge involves achieving the desirable and evading the unpleasant. Knowledge is effective in facilitating successful action by enabling the achievement of desirable objectives and the avoidance of unwanted outcomes. A cause may be either productive (karaka) or informational (jhdpaka). In that context, knowledge is solely a catalyst for successful behaviour. It enables us to achieve tangible results, which have practical efficacy.

False cognition is distinct from knowledge. Erroneous cognition leads us to pursue an object different from the one identified. Objects vary due to their shape and spatiotemporal positions. Cognition, being a representation of an item in one form, should not be deemed accurate when the actual object possesses a different shape. Similarly, cognition is inaccurate if it misrepresents the location and characteristics of an object.

In the Pranmana Vartika, Dharmakirti defines knowledge as cognition that is congruent with its object (Pramanam avisamvadi jnanam). Three, he asserts that cognition that completely aligns with its object will also exhibit novelty (Ajnata artha prakaso va). Four: It reveals an object that is not yet recognised, as the object is ephemeral, and only knowledge acquired at that precise instant aligns with the object's existence. It is the initial instance of cognition, the moment of primary awareness. Buddhists assert that continuous cognition is not genuine or true, as it constitutes recognition rather than novel cognition. Among these two properties, the

first, absence of discordance, is fundamental and might be considered the distinguishing trait of knowledge. Buddhist philosophy asserts that all phenomena are perpetually in flux. All entities are ephemeral by nature. Dharmakīrti asserts that continuous knowledge is unattainable. He contends that continuous cognition, being merely recognition, lacks authenticity and validity. Continuous cognition is not a novel concept. Consequently, he asserts that knowledge is a type of cognition that reveals the true nature of an object. The object must be disclosed in its authentic state through understanding.

Dignága

Dignaga is a well-known post-Nágárjuna Buddhist philosopher who built on the ideas of Maitreya, Asanga, and Vasubandhu by rejecting Nagarjuna's negative dialectics and replacing them with a philosophical positivism that combines the Sautrantika and Vijnanavada schools. Dignaga is credited for reconciling Sautrantika ontology with Vijnanavada ontology, formulating an epistemology and logic appropriate for this new ontology, and promoting a unique philosophical methodology grounded in the technique of apoha (double negation). He presents a novel approach to philosophy by integrating ontological discourse within an epistemological framework, a method that subsequently captivated the Navya Nyaya philosopher Ganges'a and his adherents. Dignaga employs the method of double negation (apoha) to enhance clarity and precision in cognition and language. He is an enigmatic logician. He promotes a binary classification in his reasoning. This contradiction is manifested in the promotion of two forms of reality, two ways of cognition, and two nuances of meaning. He employs the concept of svatovyavartana (mutual exclusion) in the domains of reality, knowledge, and language. In essence, each real number represents a distinct class, while all other entities form its complementary class. Consequently, there exists a distinct hierarchy within reality, comprising solely two categories of the real: svalaksana (unique specificity) and samanyalaksana (its generalised representation). What is uniquely specific cannot serve as a generalised representation, and vice versa. This inflexible dichotomy is applied to the domain of epistemology. Dinnaga's observation that every epistemology must be organised with consideration for ontological requirements was groundbreaking. In accordance with this ontological commitment in Dignaga’s epistemology, there exist exclusively two valid means of knowing: pratyaksa (perception) and anumana (inference), as well as two categories of knowledge: perceptual and inferential. The perception can only recognise the unique specific and can never comprehend its generalised representation. The inferential, conversely, perceives just the generalised image and is incapable of recognising the unique special. Similarly to the

rigid dichotomy and stringent hierarchy present in reality, there exists a rigid dichotomy and rigorous hierarchy in the realm of knowledge. Dinnaga extends this binary dichotomy to the realm of language and meaning. Each concept can be articulated in language according to its significance. A word signifies a certain concept. The definition of a term is the antithesis of its negation. Consequently, there can be no overlap or intersection in the meanings of any two words.

Dharmottara

Proper knowledge is delineated by Dharmottara, a prominent Buddhist philosopher and the author of an authoritative commentary on the Nyayābindu. He characterises proper knowledge as knowledge that can be validated. In other words, information is accurate when it aligns with objective reality. The objective of knowledge is fully realised when it accurately reflects the core of reality.

Knowledge represents intellect that accurately reflects reality. It signifies that in knowledge, the object must be understood as it truly is, not as something other. A nondeviating reference is a fundamental prerequisite for knowledge; thus, the veracity of knowledge lies in its alignment with the object of cognition. Dharmottara states, "In everyday life, when we assert that truth is being articulated, we imply that it enables us to attain an object." Likewise, cognition is valid because it directs us toward the object it signifies. Knowledge does not generate an object nor present it to us; rather, it enables us to get it. Reaching an object simply means paying attention to it. Five Dharmottara identifies three different, sequential stages in the process of object apprehension, with each subsequent step arising from the prior one. They are perceiving (adhigati), engaging (pravartana), and attaining (prapana). He asserts that the initial stage solely encompasses knowledge.

There are two categories of knowledge. It is instinctive when it originates from inside. It is discursive when it is attained by focusing our attention on an item through the senses and cognitive consciousness. Epistemology exclusively examines discursive knowledge. According to Dharmottra, there exist two categories of knowledge deemed accurate: instinctive and discursive. Knowledge that arises from inside is termed 'instinctual knowledge'. The act of focusing our attention on an object through sensory input exemplifies the presence of discursive knowledge. He asserts that when successfully gaining proper knowledge, we must ensure we have previously encountered it, as our memory motivates our will. Will propels action, and activity culminates in the attainment of the objective. This exemplifies an indirect cause,

defined as one that lacks any intermediate causal chain. On the other hand, Buddhist logic cannot analyse a deliberate action that directly achieves its objectives (instinctive knowledge). Consequently, Dharmottra underscores the need for discursive knowledge. Classical Buddhist epistemologists assert that knowledge episodes can be categorised into two fundamental types: perceptual knowledge and inferential knowledge. Buddhist epistemologists, starting with Dignāga and continuing thereafter, have concentrated on demonstrating that these two Pramanas are the sole possibilities, arguing that all forms of knowledge can ultimately be traced back to either direct perception or logical inference.

In Indian philosophy, pramāṇa signifies a valid means of knowledge—the method by which precise understanding is achieved. Buddhist epistemology offers a distinctive interpretation of pramāṇa, grounded in the Buddha's emphasis on experience, impermanence, and non-self. Buddhism, unlike most Indian philosophical traditions that acknowledge several pramāṇas, adopts a minimalist and factually based approach to knowledge. Most Buddhist traditions, especially those expressed by philosophers such as Dignāga and Dharmakīrti, recognise two pramāṇas: perception (pratyakṣa) and inference (anumāna). These two are considered sufficient for obtaining both secular information and liberating comprehension, as they provide a foundational framework for understanding reality and achieving enlightenment in Buddhist philosophy.

Perception

In Buddhist philosophy, perception is crucial for understanding the development of human experience and the origin of suffering. It is an active cognitive process that detects, interprets, and categorises experiences rather than a mere passive reception of sensory information. The Buddha examined perception to illustrate that our understanding of reality is significantly shaped by mental conditioning, making it fundamentally inaccurate, as our perceptions are often influenced by past experiences, cultural contexts, and personal biases. In Buddhism, perception is termed 'Saññā' in Pāli and 'Saṃjñā' in Sanskrit. It signifies the cognitive ability

of recognition or identification. When a human perceives an object through the senses—such as a shape through sight or a sound through hearing—perception identifies the object by identifying its characteristics and assigning it a concept or label. For example, when perceiving a particular shape and hue, recognition categorises it as "a tree". Thus, perception acts as a bridge between unprocessed sensory data and conceptual understanding.

In Buddhist epistemology, perception (pratyaksa) is considered the primary pramana. In Buddhist tradition, the term 'pramana' denotes both the process of cognition and the information obtained via it. Buddhists do not recognise a separation between the process of knowledge (pramana) and its result (pramanaphala)—prama. Buddhist philosophers assert that a distinction between the noetic process and its result is unattainable. The process of cognising is entirely synonymous with the cognition of an item. For Buddhists, knowledge is self-evident, therefore eliminating the necessity to differentiate between pramana and its phala.

In Buddhist epistemology, perception (pratyaksa) is considered the primary pramana, as inference (anumana) is contingent upon it. Inference relies on perception, so perception holds precedence over inference in this context. While all Buddhist philosophers from Dinnaga onwards agree on this matter, their interpretations of the essence of perception differ, resulting in varied definitions.

In Buddhism, all knowledge is classified as either direct or indirect. The direct is distinct from the indirect, and the indirect is distinct from the direct. Direct cognition is formally referred to as 'pratyaksa', while indirect cognition is termed 'kalpana' or 'paroksa'. Pratyaksa can thus be delineated by its differentiation from kalpana or paroksa. Consequently, pratyaksa can be interpreted as the "negation of kalpana".

In Buddhist epistemology, perception is considered the paramount Pramana. According to Dharmakirti, perception is characterised as the acknowledgement of an object's unique attributes (svalaksana), devoid of any comparison to other entities, irrespective of their similarities or differences, and entirely independent of nomenclature and verbal expressions, which are merely conceptual constructs. The reality that is immediately presented to awareness constitutes the object of perception. This contrasts with elements expressed as thoughts and words (vikalpas), which are not part of immediate sensory input but are instead constructed in the mind, highlighting the distinction between direct experience and conceptual understanding in Buddhist philosophy. Although all Buddhist philosophers, starting with Dignaga and extending thereafter, concur on this subject, their interpretations of perception's essence differ,

resulting in diverse definitions. The object of vision is distinct from both intellectual and verbal representations, as well as from anything that is solely imagined. Svalaksana, the unique attribute, is the only authentic item that is both real and functional, making it the sole element capable of eliciting a sensory response. A figment of imagination is defined as something that is conceived mentally and hence lacks the capacity to produce any form of stimulus.

According to Dharmakirti, perception entails the recognition of an object in its unique essence (svalaksana), devoid of any relation to other similar or dissimilar objects, and entirely independent of names and verbal expressions, which are mere conceptual constructs. The object of perception is the actual entity that is directly revealed to consciousness, as opposed to objects represented as concepts and words (vikalpas), which are not part of immediate sensory input but are instead formulated in the mind.

The object of perception differs not just from conceptual and verbal representations but also from mere figments of imagination. The unique specific (svalaksana) is the sole real object, and as the genuine and effective entity, it alone may elicit a sensation upon the senses. A phantasm of imagination is, by definition, unreal and thus incapable of exerting any such influence. In response to Dharmakirti's assertion in the Nydya Bindu that "all successful human action is preceded by right knowledge," Dharmottara, within the framework of perception, states that when an object is perceived through direct experience, it is transformed into an object of intentional action via sensory perception.

Inference

Anumana is regarded by Buddhists as a legitimate means of knowledge (pramana), alongside pratyaksa. The two distinct categories of knowledge are pratyaksa, signifying "instant", and paroksa, denoting "mediate". Unlike pratyaksa, the approach dubbed 'anumana' results in the attainment of just intermediary (paroksa) knowledge. Similarly, Anumana can be perceived as both an epistemological approach and a mode of reasoning. This results in the presence of both an epistemic and a logical dimension, which are closely interconnected, indicating that understanding Anumana requires both a grasp of its knowledge-based aspects and its reasoning processes. Anumana is generally recognised as a way of knowledge, as the former serves as the foundation for the latter.

Anumana is simultaneously a method of knowledge and a form of reasoning. Consequently, it possesses both an epistemic and a logical dimension, which are inextricably intertwined. The former aspect underlies the latter, which is why anumana is typically recognised as a style of knowledge.

The Buddhist concept of anumana has evolved within the framework of the dual pramanas, specifically pratyaksa and anumana, which is predicated on the notion of two categories of knowing objects (prameyas). The Buddhists propose a process-orientated perspective of reality, contrasting with the substantival approach upheld by other Indian philosophical groups. A tangible entity, characterised by discrete and transient existence, is solely provided through our sensory experience, which consists of pure feelings free from any conceptualisations.

Dinnaga provided a novel direction and energy to the exploration of logic and epistemology within the Buddhist tradition. He deserves commendation for addressing the theory of pramanas independently from the notion of prameyas. In him, and possibly in Vasubandhu preceding him, we observe an endeavour to compose autonomous treatises on pramanas without incorporating specific examinations of prameyas. He asserts that there are solely two pramanas: pratyaksa and anumana. The other pramanas, such as sabda, were diminished to anumana.

For Dinnaga, anumana may comprise a simple propositional cognitive process or may be expressed in a sentential form. A purely propositional anumana is a cognitive process that remains unarticulated verbally. He designated it as svarthdnumana. When the propositions of an anumana are articulated in language (prakasana or akhydna), they assume a sentential (s'abda) quality, and this type of anumana is referred to as pardrthdnumdna. Keith14 asserts that the differentiation between the two types of anumana was initially presented by Dinnaga in Indian logic.

Dharmakirti discusses the concepts in his works, Pramana Vartika and Nyaya Bindu. The latter study distinctly investigates and defines the fundamental concepts and terminology related to the philosophy of anumana. The subsequent sections thoroughly describe Dharmakirti's principal contribution, which is his explication of the doctrine of trairupya. The doctrine of trairupya considers hetu or linga as the foundational element of anumana and establishes its validity based on three requisite requirements that a valid hetu must satisfy. In summary, they are as follows:
Buddhism adopts a three-member syllogism, consisting of:

1. Thesis (pratijñā) – the statement to be proven

2. Reason (hetu) – the logical ground
3. Example (dṛṣṭānta) – an illustration of the universal relation

This simplified structure reflects the Buddhist emphasis on cognitive efficiency and practical reasoning.

1. There should be a necessary presence of hetu in paksa (anumeye sattvarri). This corresponds to the idea of paksadharmatva available in the Nyaya position.
2. There should be a presence of hetu only in such cases that are similar to paksa (sapakseva sattvam).
3. Lastly, there should be a necessary absence of hetu in such cases that are dissimilar to paksa (asapkse casattvameva niscitam).

The second and third conditions pertain to the two categories of vyâpti: affirmative (anvaya) and negative (vyatireki). While Dinnaga introduced these three requirements of hetu or linga, Dharmakirti provided their systematic formulations, which further refined the understanding of inference in Indian philosophy. Indeed, the entire discourse about anumana revolves around its vital role.

Although it appears that Vasubandhu initially established systematic and logical analysis, it was Dinnaga and Dharmakirti who formulated a thorough idea of anumana. Although referenced in the Pitakas, the term "anumana" is not cited within the framework of a scientific profession grounded in logic. The Anumana Sutta establishes the principle that one should abstain from treating others in a way one would not desire for oneself. The generalisation that others share an individual's aversions purports to underpin this idea. This knowledge is described as inferential.

This paradigm reflects the Buddhist focus on cognitive efficiency and practical thinking, having been streamlined accordingly. In the Buddhist tradition, inference serves not only as a means of intellectual exploration but also fulfils a soteriological purpose. Impermanence (anicca), suffering (dukkha), and non-self (anattā) are notions that can be understood by inference prior to persons directly experiencing them via meditation practice. The mind is thereby primed for insight via the process of inference, which diminishes ignorance and erroneous beliefs. Nonetheless, Buddhism recognises the limitations inherent in inference. It is

posited that the sole means of grasping ultimate reality is through direct, non-conceptual perception, as inferential knowledge is conceptual and mediated by cognition. Consequently, inference functions more as a guide than as a definitive realisation.

Knock your brain

1In Indian philosophy, the sources of valid knowledge are called:

a) Dharma

b) Pramāṇa

c) Karma

d) Mokṣa

2Which of the following is accepted as a Pramāṇa by almost all Indian philosophical schools?

a) Arthāpatti

b) Anupalabdhi

c) Pratyakṣa

d) Śabda

3Which Pramāṇa refers to knowledge gained through inference?

a) Pratyakṣa

b) Anumāna

c) Upamāna

d) Śabda

4Buddhism accepts how many Pramāṇas?

a) One

b) Two

c) Three

d) Four

5 Which two Pramāṇas are accepted by Buddhism?

a) Perception and Testimony

b) Inference and Comparison

c) Perception and Inference

d) Testimony and Presumption

Unleash your potential

1 What does Buddhist epistemology entail?

2 What are the primary sources of knowing (pramāṇas) recognised in Buddhist epistemology?